



Dear PGCE Computing candidate,

Congratulations on being shortlisted for an interview with UCL!

This guide will provide you with an outline of the Computing PGCE course and the interview process, which is a 30 minute online interview using Microsoft Teams.

FAQs

Can you tell me more about the PGCE cohort?

We have a small cohort of 20 to 25 student teachers each year. We are very pleased with the diversity of our course with around a 50/50 gender split, age range between 22 and 68 and around 60 to 70% of students from BAME backgrounds. As a group our cohort brings together an impressive range of digital knowledge and vast work experience in the field of computing.

Who will support me in subject studies?

The subject leader for the course will support and monitor your progress. He has 17 years' experience of teaching in London schools as a head of department and advisory teacher and 20 years' experience in running the PGCE and researching and writing in the field of Computing education.

How long is the course?

The PGCE is a full-time course lasting from mid-September to late June the following year. You will be required to engage fully with the course. There is no part-time option.

How is the course structured?

You will attend the university for subject studies sessions and some elements of professional studies, and you will spend around 120 days working in 2 of our partnership schools.

What will I learn in subject studies sessions?

Sessions are aligned to the Teachers' Standards, and we will look at such themes as: the Computing curriculum, approaches to teaching, assessment, planning lessons, managing in the classroom, teaching different types of pupils and professionalism. Subject studies focus on combining theory and practice and preparing you for your first year of teaching.

What will I do when I am on school placement?

Our placements team will allocate you to a school based on your home location and your particular needs as a trainee teacher. You will do two placements of around 12 weeks each. When on placement you will attend from around 8am to 4pm each day. You will gradually take over a small number of classes under the supervision of experienced staff.

Is there any coursework?

You will complete two major masters level assignments. The first will be a 5000-word task focussing on planning and teaching in your first placement school. The second will be a 3500-word report outlining the development of an e-learning resource for one of your classes.

Who and what will I teach?

You will teach secondary classes at KS 3, KS 4 and be given an opportunity to work with post 16 students under supervision. You will teach the curriculum subject Computing including a range of qualifications such as GCSE and A level.

What subject knowledge will I be expected to have?

As the course is a postgraduate course in teaching and education you will be expected to arrive with a solid base of subject knowledge. Certainly, there will be gaps in your knowledge which can be filled but significant understanding of hardware, software and programming will be needed.

What are the expectations regarding attendance and engagement?

Just like serving teachers there is an expectation of excellent attendance and punctuality. Whilst we will seek to address constraints for those with family responsibilities etc. you will be needed to attend a school each day as if it were your permanent place of work.

What qualities must I have to successfully engage with the course?

Successful students work hard, manage their time well and demonstrate resilience when presented with challenges. Whilst they receive school and university guidance, students are expected to show self-motivation, creativity, and energy.

What qualifications do I get on completion of the course?

Upon the successful completion of the course candidates receive:

- QTS - Qualified Teacher Status.
- A Postgraduate Certificate in Education – PGCE (60 Masters level credits)

Preparing for your on-line interview

Before the interview:

At least 3 days prior to your interview, please compose a written response to the following question:

“What do you see as the key personal and professional qualities of a teacher of Computing and how might these shape positive classroom relationships. Also, please comment on the qualities you have which would help you form positive and appropriate working relationships with pupils.”

Please write in standard English paying attention to spelling, punctuation, and grammar. Please write between 250 and 300 words. Send your written response to adrian.mee@ucl.ac.uk **at least 3 days before the interview date** and ensure that your submission contains your full name as in your application.

Interviews must be conducted in a quiet space, and please check your audio and camera settings. Please note we run interviews consecutively and if you are late, we will need to move on to the next applicant.

The interview will have four parts:

1. About you

This will give you an opportunity to tell us about your academic and relevant work experience. We may ask you to explain why you wish to be a teacher and ask you about what you see as the teacher's role. We will ask about relevant experience if you have any.

2. Your knowledge of computing as a school subject in the English curriculum.

In this section we will be looking at your knowledge of the subject including subject knowledge and curriculum knowledge. Clearly, we don't expect you to know everything about the subject so we will be looking for your strengths and development needs. We will ask you some simple questions about topics such as computer networks or programming and about the nature and structure of the curriculum.

We will ask you some questions about the code below.

The area of a circle is calculated using the formula $\pi \times r^2$, where π is equal to 3.142 and r is the radius.

Finn has written a program to allow a user to enter the radius of a circle as a whole number, between 1 and 30, and output the area of the circle.

```
01  int radius = 0
02  real area = 0.0
03  input radius
04  if radius < 1 OR radius > 30 then
05    print ('Sorry, that radius is invalid')
06  else
07    area = 3.142 * (radius ^ 2)
08    print (area)
09  end if
```

In preparing for this section, you might like to look at BBC bitesize - <https://www.bbc.co.uk/bitesize/examspecs/zmtchbk>

(You don't need to know all of the content above!! But browsing the Bitesize site will give you an overview of the GCSE in Computer Science.)

3. Classroom scenarios

In this section we will ask you to give us your perspective on the following situations.

Situation 1 – You have a class who work well in the classroom but many of them don't produce homework. We would like you to tell us how you might approach this problem.

Situation 2 – You have a class with very mixed abilities. Some find the work easy, and others struggle. How might you address this when planning your lessons?

Situation 3 – You have been asked to teach a lesson to a GCSE class about a topic you are unfamiliar with. How would you prepare to teach the lesson?

4. Final questions

In this final part we will ask any outstanding questions we have about your particular application, and you will be given an opportunity to ask questions.

Some important notes

- We do not expect you to be an expert in all areas of GCSE Computing, but you must have sufficient subject knowledge to start the course.
- We expect applicants to have a passing familiarity with the nature of the school curriculum in England e.g., what is taught, its structure and assessment e.g., examinations.
- This is a popular course, and we have a responsibility to offer our limited places to the best candidates and inevitably some candidates will be disappointed. If we reject your application, we will provide brief feedback but cannot engage in lengthy discussions about the reasons for rejection.
- If you are unable to participate in the interview, you must let us know as soon as possible and we will endeavour to provide an alternative date. However please note that places are offered to suitable applicants on a first-come basis and deferring an interview could mean losing a place on the course.
- UCL is not responsible for any expenses involved in participating in this interview.

- If you have a disability, sensory impairment, medical condition, or mental health difficulty which means you will need extra support at your interview, please ensure you contact us as soon as possible via computingPGCE@ucl.ac.uk so that suitable support can be arranged. If you don't let us know, there is no guarantee that support will be available on the day.

Please do not hesitate to contact us if you have any queries and we look forward to seeing you on the day of your interview!

Yours sincerely,
PGCE Computing Dept - computingPGCE@ucl.ac.uk